

I get the shit kicked out of me. Then I get the shit kicked out of me again. You know what I've learned down here? Humility. Discipline. You come into this business with any sense of superiority, and you're dead.

Sooner or later, you find out who you are. That's what this game is about, finding out who you are. People say the market's this or the market's that, and they begin to think they can understand it. They discover they're wrong. They can't understand it. The market is . . . the market is God."

With that extraordinary speech, Mr. Dickman disappeared into the center of the corn pit. Mr. Sullivan, who'd been standing by quietly, returned me to the trading desk to record my corn sale. I'd sold 5,000 bushels, with the proceeds already credited to my account.

I went upstairs to the visitor's gallery to watch the closing of the grain markets. A few seconds before the 2:00 P.M. closing bell, the entire trading floor went berserk, as if all traders had suffered simultaneous epileptic seizures. After the bell rang, it was silent as prayer. On the overhead quote board, I could see the price of corn had already dropped a tenth of a cent. What was bad for the physical farmers was good for me.